

guest column

Dean D'Cruz

PARADISE BEING LOST

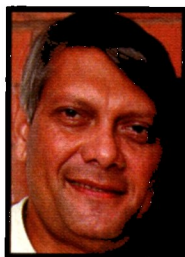
The recent rape of a Britisher on a beach of Goa has grabbed a great deal of media attention. But Goa's rape itself is going largely unnoticed and unreported. There are two rapists of Goa—unscrupulous developers coming up with large speculative housing schemes and grabbing large tracts of coastal land with political connivance and the mining mafia ravaging the foothills, forest areas and farmlands of Goa in the interior.

Most of the new properties are bought for investment or as second holiday homes. Developers have found ways to convert new areas by extending the planning areas through Outline Development Plans well beyond the city limits extending into fields and sensitive orchard lands. Even basic laws like Coastal Regulatory Zone (CRZ) notifications are being flouted brazenly with the full support of local MLAs and sarpanchs as can be seen in the Calangute-Candolim belt.

In Dona Paula, the controversial Aldeia de Goa project is being promoted by NCP bigwigs. It violates the CRZ as well as hill slope protection laws. In fact, when taken to court, two very different plans with the same date and licence number for the project appeared. When this was brought to the notice of the court, the files disappeared from both the town planning and the panchayat offices and the town planning office has now admitted that what is actually being implemented is a third design that does not respond to either of those plans.

The plateaus of the state are now being eyed by developers as there are large tracts of land, mostly owned by comunidades (community organisations which jointly own the land) that according to their own memoranda allows only for agricultural use. The comunidade is a pre-Portuguese system where common land was utilised through annual auctioning of sections of its fields and hills for agriculture. Most of these

Unscrupulous developers and mining mafia together are killing the spirit of Goa as a tourist spot



comunidades are now corrupt and easy prey for government and private acquisitions. While the fields are extremely fertile, the seemingly barren plateaus are also high on bio-diversity, as spelt out in a number of scientific reports and need protection.

SEZs is another scam where tracts of land acquired from comunidades for a few rupees per sq m, are sold to developers at a couple of hundred rupees per sq m, at one-tenth the market prices. The Rahejas for example, were given land for industrial purposes at Rs 600 per sq m and they promptly came up with an enormous housing project. Responding to public outcry, the Government has decided to scrap the proposed SEZs across the state but the Goa Industrial Development Corporation is still on an acquisition spree.

Regarding indiscriminate mining: most people who visit Goa do not see this destruction as it takes place in the interiors. However, a visit to Google earth exposes the full extent of this devastation. A number of mines operate at 600 to 800 ft below sea level, thus, depleting the water table in the adjoining forests and field lands. The police unfortunately are controlled by the politicians and the system is in a shambles. Here corruption, as I learnt, starts at the lowest level—a young boy from my village approached me to put up part of Rs 80,000 he needed to pay as a bribe to get a job in the police force.

Goa had reached its carrying capacity long ago with a number of charters now pulling out

saying it is becoming a decrepit destination. Yet strangely, new hotels are coming up, off-shore casinos being touted and beach shacks continue to have a free run of the coast. From a tourism standpoint, it looks like the vision for Goa is to create a place that is a cross between Nepal and Bangkok. It is sad to say that the state, once a little paradise, and is now being lost.

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